

LABOUR

1. Passage anchor

> “...I was looking for something that could pull me in without feeling like ****hard labour****.”

Passage meaning

****labour**** = hard, tiring, or unpleasant work requiring a lot of effort

****苦工；辛苦工作；費力的工作****

Here, the speaker means they wanted a book that was engaging without feeling exhausting or difficult to get through.

Practice

1. Reading the book never felt like ****hard labour****.

讀這本書從來不會讓人覺得像在做****苦工****。

2. The assignment felt more like ****labour**** than learning.

那份作業感覺更像****苦差事****，而不是學習。

Core meanings of LABOUR

2. labour — hard physical work

= difficult physical work requiring effort

****勞動；體力勞動；苦工****

Examples

1. The job involves heavy manual ****labour****.

這份工作涉及繁重的****體力勞動****。

2. Building the wall required hours of ****labour****.

建造那面牆需要數小時的****勞動****。

This is the central traditional sense.

3. manual labour

= physical work done mainly with the body rather than intellectual or office work

****體力勞動；勞力工作****

Examples

1. He spent years doing ****manual labour****.
他多年來一直從事****體力勞動****。
2. The work involves both planning and ****manual labour****.
這份工作同時涉及規劃和****體力工作****。

Work / effort generally

4. labour — work and effort

= work, especially when it requires sustained effort

****工作；勞力；努力****

Examples

1. The project required months of ****labour****.
這個專案需要數月的****辛勤工作****。
2. Their ****labour**** finally produced results.
他們的****努力工作****終於有了成果。

5. a labour of love

= work done because you enjoy or care deeply about it, not mainly for money

****出於熱愛而做的工作；心血之作****

Examples

1. Restoring the house was a ****labour of love****.
修復那棟房子是一項****出於熱愛的工作****。
2. The book was clearly a ****labour of love****.
這本書顯然是一部****心血之作****。

Very high-value fixed expression.

Workers collectively

6. labour — workers as a group

= workers considered collectively, especially those who do paid or manual work

****勞工；勞動人口****

Examples

1. The industry relies heavily on skilled ****labour****.

這個行業非常依賴技術****勞工****。

2. There is a shortage of ****labour****.

目前存在****勞工短缺****。

Major economic/social sense.

7. skilled / unskilled labour

= workers with / without specialized training

****技術勞工 / 非技術勞工****

Examples

1. The sector needs more ****skilled labour****.

這個行業需要更多****技術勞工****。

2. Much of the work was done by ****unskilled labour****.

很多工作由****非技術勞工****完成。

Economics: labour as factor of production

8. labour — human work in economics

= human effort used in producing goods and services

****勞動；勞動力****

Examples

1. Economics often treats ****labour**** as a factor of production.

經濟學常把****勞動****視為生產要素之一。

2. The cost of **labour** increased.

勞動成本上升了。

9. labour costs

= money paid for workers' time and work

人工成本；勞工成本

Examples

1. Rising **labour costs** affected profits.

上升的**人工成本**影響了利潤。

2. The company reduced **labour costs**.

公司降低了**勞工成本**。

10. labour market

= system or market involving employers, workers, jobs, wages, and employment

勞動市場；就業市場

Examples

1. The **labour market** remains competitive.

勞動市場仍然競爭激烈。

2. Graduates entered a difficult **labour market**.

畢業生進入了一個艱難的**就業市場**。

Childbirth

11. labour — childbirth process

= process in which a pregnant person's body prepares for and gives birth to a baby

分娩；產程；陣痛期

Examples

1. She went into **labour** early in the morning.

她清晨開始**進入產程**。

2. The **labour** lasted several hours.

分娩過程持續了幾個小時。

Major distinct sense.

12. go into labour

= begin the process of childbirth

開始分娩；進入產程

Examples

1. She **went into labour** at midnight.

她半夜**開始分娩**。

2. They went to the hospital when she **went into labour**.

她**進入產程**後，他們去了醫院。

13. labour pains

= painful contractions during childbirth

產痛；陣痛

Examples

1. She began experiencing **labour pains**.

她開始出現**陣痛**。

2. The **labour pains** became stronger.

產痛變得更強烈。

Verb: work hard

14. labour — work hard

= work with great effort, often for a long time

辛苦工作；勞動；費力做

Examples

1. They **laboured** all day in the heat.

他們整天在炎熱中**辛苦工作**。

2. She **laboured** over the report for hours.

她花了幾小時**費力撰寫**那份報告。

15. labour over something

= spend a lot of time and effort doing something carefully or painfully

費力處理；苦心做

Examples

1. He **laboured** over every sentence.

他對每一句話都**反覆斟酌、費盡心力**。

2. She **laboured** over the design for weeks.

她為那個設計**苦心鑽研**了幾星期。

Very useful figurative verb sense.

Move with difficulty

16. labour — move or function with difficulty

= move, breathe, or operate with visible effort

艱難地移動；費力運作

Examples

1. The old engine **laboured** up the hill.

舊引擎**吃力地**爬上山坡。

2. He was **labouring** to breathe.

他正**艱難地呼吸**。

Distinct extension from effort.

Overemphasize

17. labour the point

= explain or emphasize something too much, especially after it is already understood

****反覆強調；把一點講得太多****

Examples

1. I don't want to ****labour the point****.

我不想****反覆強調這一點****。

2. She had already understood, so there was no need to ****labour the point****.

她已經明白了，所以沒必要****再三強調****。

High-value BrE expression.

Under a mistaken belief

18. labour under a misconception / illusion

= continue believing something that is false

****抱有錯誤觀念；誤以為****

Examples

1. He was ****labouring under the misconception**** that the meeting had been cancelled.

他一直****誤以為****會議已取消。

2. They were ****labouring under an illusion****.

他們一直****抱著錯誤幻想****。

Formal.

Political name

19. Labour

Capitalized:

= name used by political parties associated historically with labour movements, especially the Labour Party in the UK and similar parties elsewhere

****工黨****

Examples

1. She joined the **Labour Party**.
她加入了**工黨**。
2. **Labour** announced a new policy.
工黨公布了一項新政策。

Capitalization is essential.

Related forms

20. labourer

= person whose job involves physical work
勞工；苦力；工人

Examples

1. He worked as a construction **labourer**.
他是一名建築**工人**。
2. The site employed dozens of **labourers**.
工地僱用了數十名**勞工**。

21. labour-intensive

= requiring a large amount of human work
勞力密集的；需要大量人力的

Examples

1. Farming can be very **labour-intensive**.
農業可以非常**勞力密集**。
2. The process is too **labour-intensive**.
這個流程需要**大量人力**。

22. labour-saving

= reducing the amount of human work needed

****省力的；節省人力的****

Examples

1. The machine is a useful ****labour-saving device****.

這部機器是一項實用的****省力設備****。

2. Automation introduced several ****labour-saving methods****.

自動化引入了幾種****節省人力的方法****。

23. labour force

= all people who are working or available to work in an economy

****勞動人口；勞動力****

Examples

1. The country has an aging ****labour force****.

該國的****勞動人口****正在老化。

2. More women entered the ****labour force****.

更多女性進入了****勞動市場 / 勞動人口****。

High-value expressions

24. hard labour

A. very difficult physical work

****苦工；繁重勞動****

B. historically, punishment involving forced physical work

****苦役****

Examples

1. Moving the stones was ****hard labour****.

搬那些石頭是很辛苦的****苦工****。

2. Historically, some prisoners were sentenced to ****hard labour****.

歷史上，有些囚犯曾被判處****苦役****。

The passage uses the figurative everyday sense, not penal labour.

25. the fruits of your labour

= results or rewards produced by your work

****勞動成果；辛勞所得****

Examples

1. At last, they enjoyed the ****fruits of their labour****.

他們終於享受到****辛勞的成果****。

2. The finished house was the ****fruit of years of labour****.

完工的房子是多年****辛勞的成果****。

Spelling note

26. labour vs labor

Both spellings represent the same word.

British English

****labour****

American English

****labor****

The passage uses British-style spelling:

> ****hard labour****

Do not treat ****labour**** and ****labor**** as different meanings.

Key contrasts

27. labour vs work

****work****

= broad neutral word for activity requiring effort

****工作****

****labour****

= often emphasizes physical effort, sustained difficulty, workers collectively, or childbirth

****勞動；辛苦工作；勞工；分娩****

Compare:

> office work

> 辦公室工作

> manual labour

> 體力勞動

28. labour vs job

****job****

= particular paid position or specific task

****工作；職位****

****labour****

= work/effort itself, not normally a specific employment position

Compare:

> I have a new job.

> 我有一份新工作。

> The task requires a lot of labour.

> 這項任務需要大量勞力。

29. labour vs effort

****effort****

= energy used to achieve something

****努力；力氣****

****labour****

= actual sustained work, often difficult or physical

****勞動；辛勞****

30. labour vs workforce

****labour****

= workers as an economic resource or group

****workforce****

= people employed by a particular company, industry, or country

****勞動人口；員工隊伍****

They overlap but are not identical.

31. labour vs childbirth

Learners must recognize the dramatic context shift:

> manual ****labour****

> → 體力勞動

but:

> go into ****labour****

> → 開始分娩

Same spelling, completely different lexical branch.

Meaning map

The central historical concept of ****labour**** is:

****sustained effortful work****

From this develop:

Physical work

manual labour

→ ****體力勞動****

General effort

months of labour

→ **辛勤工作**

Passage

hard labour

→ **苦工 / 很費力的工作**

Workers collectively

labour

→ **勞工 / 勞動力**

Economics

labour market

→ **勞動市場**

Verb

labour over a task

→ **苦心做 / 費力處理**

Difficulty

engine labours

→ **吃力運作**

A separate established biological branch is:

Childbirth

labour

→ **分娩 / 產程**

And a political proper-name branch is:

Labour

→ **工黨**

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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labour — physical work	需要大量體力與努力的工作；勞動 / 苦工
manual labour	主要依靠體力完成的工作；體力勞動
labour — general effort/work	長時間投入的辛勤工作 / 勞力
a labour of love	因熱愛而非主要為金錢所做的工作；心血之作
labour — workers collectively	作為整體看待的勞工 / 勞動人口
skilled/unskilled labour	技術 / 非技術勞工
labour — economics	生產商品與服務所投入的人力；勞動力
labour costs	僱用人力所產生的人工 / 勞工成本
labour market	僱主、工作、工人及薪酬構成的勞動 / 就業市場
labour — childbirth	生產嬰兒的分娩過程 / 產程
go into labour	開始分娩 / 進入產程
labour pains	分娩時的子宮收縮疼痛；陣痛
labour — verb work hard	長時間、費很大力氣地工作
labour over something	為某事花大量時間和心力；苦心處理
labour — move/function with difficulty	吃力地移動、呼吸或運作
labour the point	對已經明白的重點反覆講述或強調
labour under a misconception	持續抱著一個錯誤觀念 / 誤解
Labour — political	大寫時可指英國等地的工黨
labourer	主要從事體力工作的勞工 / 工人
labour-intensive	需要大量人力投入的；勞力密集的
labour-saving	能減少所需人工與勞力的；省力的
labour force	正在工作或可投入工作的勞動人口
hard labour — ordinary	非常辛苦、費力的工作；苦工
hard labour — penal	歷史上作為刑罰的強迫苦役
fruits of your labour	工作與努力所產生的成果 / 回報

Passage recap

> “...something that could pull me in without feeling like **hard labour**.”

Here:

hard labour = **work that feels very difficult, tiring, and effortful**

Best Traditional Chinese:

* **苦工**

* **辛苦工作**

* contextually: **讀起來像在做苦工一樣**

Natural contextual translation:

****我很想找一本既能吸引我讀下去、又不會讓我覺得像在做苦工一樣的書。****

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

****labour****

= ****hard or sustained work requiring considerable effort****

****勞動；辛苦工作；苦工****

The passage uses it metaphorically:

> reading an overly demanding book

> → feels like ****hard labour****

So the speaker is not saying reading is literal manual labour. The phrase emphasizes that they wanted something ****engaging without being mentally exhausting or effortful****.